

Law of Similarity

What is it?

People group elements that share similar visual traits like color, size, shape, or style.

History

Defined in Gestalt psychology around **1920**, showing that the brain quickly categorizes items based on visual similarity to speed up recognition and understanding.

The Psychology Behind It

- Similar items are mentally grouped together
- Faster pattern recognition reduces cognitive effort
- Shared characteristics imply meaningful relationships
- Too much similarity can blur distinctions

Why It Matters

- Enhances user experience by increasing clarity
- Risks misinterpretation when similarities are not intentional
- Can confuse if all elements look too similar
- Excessive repetition reduces visual interest

How to Apply It

- Group elements to establish hierarchy and meaning
- Use contrast to separate primary CTAs or key interactions
- Apply white space and variation to break visual monotony

Theory in Action

- Google uses consistent brand colors across products to create instant identity recognition
- Coca-Cola maintains a unified red and white theme across packaging and brand touchpoints

Final Thought

Similarity helps the mind organize information quickly.

Use it intentionally to communicate structure — while balancing contrast so important elements still stand out.

